

Course report – Free standing courses and courses within Europaprogrammet (EP), Master of European Studies (MAES), Master of European Studies Humanities track (HMAES), Executive Master of European Studies (EMAES)

Course name, course code, programme and semester Applied Qualitative Research Methods, Problems and Design, SF2323 Fall 2023	Course instructors' name och e-mail Henrik Friberg-Fernros henrik.friberg-fernros@pol.gu.se Anna Persson anna.persson@pol.gu.se
Output and achievement	Admitted: 71; Registered: 64; Completed the course: 47; Pass as the final grade: 33; High pass 13.
Note to the reader	Before we begin any discussion on the results of the course evaluation, it should be made clear that only 23 out of the 64 registered students responded to the evaluation – which corresponds to only 37 percent. One should thus be careful in making any more general assessments of the course solely based on the course evaluation.

Impressions of course execution: general and specific	Overall, our impression is that the course went quite well. Even this semester, the course benefited from the quite thorough re-organization in terms of both structure and content that was made in 2021. The new structure begins with an introduction of core themes of qualitative research design, including problem formulation, comparative research design, process-tracing techniques, research ethics, and source criticism. This works very well in terms of defining the overall framework of conducting qualitative research. Following from this set of introductory lectures, the students are then introduced to four different branches of qualitative data collection and methods; interviews, observations, discourse analysis and typology analysis. Out of these four themes, the students are asked to choose two (either interviews or observations and discourse analysis or typology analysis) to dig further into. The course is concluded with a research proposal on a topic of the students' own choice, with a focus on methodology and design. In preparation of the final research proposal, the students are offered both an introductory lecture with advice and ideas about how to write a research proposal, two group supervisions, and – new for this year – an individual Q&A. Overall, the execution of the course worked well with the exception for the administration of Canvas with regard to scheduling, which was riddled with problems during the course (this is also the main line of complaint in the students' evaluation of the course). A few things that came up in the course evaluation regarding the execution of the course and that can be considered when we further develop the course are: 1) The organization of the course on Canvas; 2) Even further homogenize the group assignments and the seminars for the final papers; 3) Similar to previous years; try to make the course as relevant for all students, despite them having very different backgrounds in terms of methodological training.
Impressions of the students' general views on the course	Overall, the students seem ok happy with the course: 52.2 percent found the course very good (13) or good (39.1) and many express that the course was well-received both in terms of structure and content. Compared to last year, the numbers have thus gone down somewhat. Last year, 57.1 percent found the course very good (21.4) or good (35.7). The results are somewhat more positive compared to last year's evaluation if we take into account the students that were not very satisfied; whereas last year 21,4 percent of the students reported that they found the course very (7.1) or rather (14.3) bad, this year the corresponding number is 21.1 (4.3 percent very bad and 13 percent rather bad).

	Even though we see a shift downward since last year, the students seem more satisfied with the lectures and seminars than with the overall course: 60.9 percent found them very good (26.1 percent) or good (34.8 percent), whereas only 2 respondents (8.7percent) found them (very or) rather bad. Last year, 71.4 percent found them very good (14.3) or good (57.1), whereas 14.3 percent found them very or rather bad. The students moreover seem fairly happy with the literature: 56.5 percent found it very good (8.7) or good (47.8), whereas only 1 respondent found it (very or) rather (4.3 percent) bad. This can be compared to last year, when 61.5 percent found it very good (23.1) or good (38.5), whereas 3 respondents found it very (7.7 percent) or rather (15.4 percent) bad. What the slight drop in numbers since last year's results of the evaluation stem from is difficult to say, but it does not seem to stem from dissatisfaction with the lectures and seminars but perhaps rather from the problems with the scheduling on Canvas, which stands out in terms of negative comments. But once again; one should be careful in drawing any broader conclusions given the limited number of students that responded to the course evaluation.
Impressions of the students' specific views on the course	The students' specific views on the course reflect the overall quite positive feedback in the evaluations. However, if we are look for more negative strands of comments, the main such strand seems to concern the problems with scheduling on Canvas. Apart from this, the students' comments are rather scattered. But comments that can be found in the evaluation include wishes for the course to better adhere to the students that already had some significant methodological training previous to the course. In terms of workload, very few students (1) seem to find the course somewhat too demanding (or much too demanding) and only 4 students in total find it not that demanding (2 student) or not at all demanding (2 students). Instead, the large majority – 78.3 84.6 percent finds it OK. This is about the same as last year's evaluation, when 84.6 percent found the demands OK. At the same time, the evaluation reveals that 65.2 percent of the respondents have spent equal or less than 20 hours studying during the course, while only 8.7 percent of the respondents report that they have spent even close to 40 hours on the course by ticking in the box 31-40 hours. How these figures should be interpreted is not entirely clear. A general view among the coordinators and teachers of the course is that the fact that there is no entrance requirements in terms of any previous knowledge of qualitative methods makes it a demanding course for teachers in terms of striking the right balance between students that already have a lot of knowledge and students that have in principal never encountered qualitative methods before. In this light – and with the backdrop of the fact that the greatest majority of students do not even remotely seem to spend 40 hours a week on the course – it remains an open question whether the fact that a vast majority of this year's respondents find the course is OK in terms of demands is a sign of that the teachers have managed to balance the varying backgrounds, or if it is rather a reflection of that students feel at home with the course (maybe since it gives them time to concentrate on other things)? The fact that only 47 out of 64 registered students have so far passed the course (13 with a high pass), adds even further to the confusion in terms of how the responses concerning effort and satisfaction regarding the level of demands should be interpreted.
Ideas about potential changes for the next time the course is given	Even though the course has undergone significant change as late as two years ago, there is always room for improvement. Apart from the obvious problems with the scheduling on Canvas, which of course needs to be taken care of, one thing that came up in the course evaluation regarding the execution of the course and that can be considered when we further develop the course is to consider further homogenizing the group assignments and the seminars for the final papers.

	The quite many students that have not yet finalized the course might bear witness of that the goals are still set somewhat too high given the background knowledge of the students. At the same time, however, as aforementioned, when asked how many hours they put into their studies each week, 0 percent report that they put in more than 40 hours, whereas 65.2 of the respondents report that they have spent equal or less than 20 hours studying during the course. These figures might indicate that the course is in fact not too demanding, but rather that many of the students do not prioritize their studies.
Ideas for long-term and / or more extensive changes	As the course was very much revised in 2020 – and since the course still got quite good feedback in the student evaluation – as for now, we plan to change the course primarily in line with the points listed above.
"Aha Experiences" during the course of the course	Among the respondents, 30.4 percent reported that they got an “Aha experience” during the course. To us teachers, whereas maybe not an “Aha experience” in that regard, what once again is made clear is the importance of introductory lectures to frame the course in a nice and coherent manner, as well as the importance of time to dedicate to the students’ needs and demands. Again this year, the student group was quite diverse in many different aspects, which require more in terms of the time and resources needed to meet the issues that come up (spanning from feelings of homesickness to worries about not being able to meet the standards set for the course).
Expressions of how the Canvas-page and other administrative processes been like	Overall, the majority of respondents seem to be ok satisfied with the administration of the course: 54.5 percent report that they find the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas, to be very (22.7 percent) or rather (31.8 percent) good. Even though the majority of the respondents seem to be ok happy with the organization of Canvas, the critique directed against the course as reflected in the students’ comments this year very much concerned problems with scheduling on Canvas. This is of course something we take seriously and will improve before next year’s course
Other:	

* The Course reporting aims at responsiveness to the students' views, quality assurance of the business as well as subject and educational development. The report should have a forward-looking focus, based on the reflector's and visions of the course manager, and based on a compilation of impressions derived from the following amounts of material: comments by students individually or in groups; teacher's, study administrator and student counselor's views and impressions from the students; miter mining evaluation and the results from the course evaluation poll.